Beyond the COMIC MASK

*Veteran actor **Rakesh Bedi** explores his journey from comedy to the gritty world of* Dhurandhar

Photograph by
BANDEEP SINGH



Q. You are known for comedy, but Jameel Jamali in *Dhurandhar* is a major shift. How did you land the role and prepare for it?

It was a natural process. I worked with Aditya Dhar in *Uri*; he liked my work, and things progressed from there. As for preparation, my method is very internal. I don't look like I am obsessively immersed in it, but before shooting, the entire scene plays out in my mind.

Q. Do you feel that your image as a comic actor overshadowed the serious actor within you?

Not at all. I never gave up on experimentation. I have been continuously doing theatre. Agatha Christie's famous play *Three Blind Mice* has been running continuously in London since 1955; we did its Hindi adaptation titled *Andhe Chuhe*, in which I played the lead role of the murderer and performed nearly 150 shows.

Q. Character actors held a distinct importance during the era of films like *Chashme Buddoor*. Do they still receive the same respect and status?

Chashme Buddoor was an iconic film that remains relevant among youth even today. However, at that time, neither I nor the film received any major awards. Times have changed now. Good characters are recognised and appreciated immediately.

Q. You are finally getting this widespread recognition. Do you feel it's long overdue?

Many struggle with the feeling of being overlooked, but I believe in the right season for everything. If people didn't recognise it then, it was their limitation, not mine. Now that the work is visible and the love is pouring in, there is no room for regret.

—with Anjum Sharma